

MINDFULNESS "WHAT" SKILLS – OBSERVE
BENEFITS OF OBSERVING – WHY DO WE OBSERVE?



- **We observe to see what is.**

"Observing is like walking across a room full of furniture with your eyes open instead of closed. You can walk across the room either way. However, you will be more effective with your eyes open. If you don't like the furniture in the room, you might want to close your eyes, but ultimately it is not very effective. You keep running into the furniture."

- We all walk through life with "our eyes closed" at times, but opening our eyes and actually observing what is there can be very helpful. Observing brings us into contact with the real, factual, present moment. This is where we all actually live- in the here and now. We can't experience the past, we can't experience the future and if we're living in the past or future, we're not really living. Observing is all about learning to feel fully alive in the here and now.
- Observing is the opposite of multitasking, and it can make us more effective at the task at hand. (ie. driving – focused, observing, good driver vs. multitasking, distracted, poor driving)
- **We observe to get information into our brain so that we can change.**
Research shows that information coming into our senses will help us change in desired ways, i.e. Sleep diary, or food diary --- tracking alone can help change the behavior it measures
- **We observe to practice training the mind to pay attention.**
"The untrained mind is like an untrained puppy – gets into trouble, pees where it is not supposed to, chews up the owner's favourite shoes, eats garbage and throws up. Likewise, an untrained mind wanders all over, gets itself and the person in trouble, and ruminates about things that make the person feel worse."



THERE ARE TWO WAYS TO OBSERVE:

1. **Focusing the mind:** Using a sensory focus to observe – i.e. the breath, the feel of your hand on the table, a mantra like "wise mind" that you keep coming back to. Focusing the mind is a good place to start practicing observing.
2. **Opening the mind:** instead of focusing on specific activities, objects or events, we focus our attention on observing or watching whatever comes into awareness as it comes in and as it goes out. Noticing thoughts, emotions and sensations that enter awareness, without holding onto or pursuing the topics that come into mind. The key is to expand awareness to moment-to-moment experience. This is like sitting watching an operating conveyor belt, noticing the objects that go by on the belt but without shutting down the belt to look at the objects more closely. Opening the mind is more challenging than focusing the mind. Start practicing with focusing the mind before moving on to opening the mind.

WHAT HELPS TO PRACTICE OBSERVING:

- **Beginner's Mind:** Each moment in the universe is completely new. This one moment, right now, has never occurred before. In "beginner's mind", we focus our minds on noticing the experience of each moment, noticing that each moment is new and unique. It is easy to forget this. We forget to observe and notice the moment. Beginner's mind is trying to look at things with the eyes of a curious child who experiences everything for the first time.
- **Teflon or "Non-Stick" Mind:** Allowing emotions, thoughts, images and sensations to come and go is central to mindful observing. A Teflon mind is important in both focusing and opening the mind. The idea is to let all experiences flow out of the mind rather than grabbing experiences, holding onto them, or pushing experiences away. In focusing the mind this is helpful when dealing with distractions and intruding thoughts.

"Think of sitting on a hill looking down on a train going by. Some cars are thoughts strung together. They come into view. They go out of view. Some cars are emotions or feelings. They all come and go. Watch, observe, but do not get on the train. If you got on the train, notice, jump off, and return to observing."



We know from research that trying to STOP our SHUT OUT our thoughts is the best way to keep having them. The harder a person tries to shut a thought out, the more it will pop back into the mind. The best way to get relief from unwanted thoughts is to step back and simply observe. They will go away by themselves

- **Keep bringing the mind back to observing.** Again and again. Practice noticing distractions and noticing when the mind veers off. The noticing is the practice. This is what will build the "mindfulness muscle". *"Think of gently reeling in the fishing line as you bring the mind back. Other helpful images are: gently taking a child by the hand and guiding them back; gently walking a puppy back to the "stay" spot."*



- **Practice Wordless Watching – Observe without Describing.**

This can be very hard as we are automatically used to jumping from observation to description, applying labels to things we experience. You will need a lot of practice. We hear "chirp chirp" and we think "bird" or "singing"; we hear "woof woof" and we think "barking" or "dog". In reality, these are just sounds and adding descriptions is making assumptions about our experience, not staying with just the facts. Observing is noticing the SOUND of "chirp" or "woof", that's it. We cannot observe while describing at the same time.